

Introduction:

We don't often think of Christianity being promiscuous, and yet there is a kind of celebrated promiscuity throughout our this passage?

- What does it mean to be promiscuous? What do we normally associate it with? How do we see promiscuity in our passage today in Christ? In the Woman at the well?

Read Passage and Pray:

Observations:

I. Immediate Context: vs. 1-27

- Vs. 1: "Had to" travel through Samaria—double meaning? A Geographical and theological meaning—in what sense did Jesus "have to" travel through Samaria relative to who God is in Christ and his mission? What was Samaria to the Jews?
- Christ's disclosure and the woman discovery of grace...
- Vs. 27: The conversation between the woman and Jesus is suddenly interrupted by the return of their disciples. Notice their question to Jesus and how it suggests that Jesus, from the standpoint of the social and religious customs of 1st century Judaism, was being "promiscuous." Explain this.

II. Scene 1: A Spontaneous and Promiscuous Response in the Woman, vs. 28-30

- The woman has all but forgotten her original purpose at the well. She *"left her water jar and..."*
- Why was it "promiscuous" of her? What did she recklessly disclose in her urgency to tell people about Christ? What does this suggest about her new identity, her experience with Christ? Could she had been a better "witness"—what were her credentials?
- **"Come and See"**—this has great significance in John, as it is frequently descriptive of what people say when they have encountered Christ! (1:39, 46, 11:34, etc) Interestingly, in other gospels as well, those who encounter Christ are also described as somewhat recklessly going out, sometimes even against Christ's advice, and "bringing" people to Christ—literally! (Mt. 4:24, 8:16, 9:52, etc.)
- **CLEARLY John sees this as paradigmatic of what a genuine encounter and experience with Jesus will look like? Is this our experience? Perhaps we can remember such a time in our life when we were more reckless, even as we should perhaps ponder why we are not now so reckless? Or perhaps you can tell about such a "reckless" event in your life recently?**

III. Scene 2: A Deeply Theological Disclosure with the Disciples, vs. 31-36

"My food is to do the will of him who sent me and to complete his work.

- What does "eating" represent? And was Christ's point, don't ever eat? If not, then what was his point?
- First things first: Christ clearly had a redemptive historical understanding of life, and especially as this fit his mission in life? What was it? And how does this story illustrate it?
- John Calvin said it this way:

He only points out what he must do first, and what must be done afterwards; and thus he shows, by his example, that the kingdom of God ought to be preferred to all the comforts of the body. God allows us, indeed, to eat and drink, provided that we are not withdrawn from what is of the highest importance; that is, that every man attend to his own calling. he who endeavors to nourish his body with sobriety and moderation does not fail to give that preference which he ought to give to obedience to God. But we must also take care not to adhere so firmly to our fixed hours, as not to be prepared to deprive ourselves of food, when God holds out to us any opportunity, and, as it were, fixes the present hour. Christ, having now in his hands such an opportunity which might pass away, embraces it with open arms, and holds it fast.... It was to advance the kingdom of God, to restore to life lost souls, to spread the light of the Gospel, and, in

short, to bring salvation to the world. The excellence of these things caused him, when fatigued and hungry, to forget meat and drink.

- **The most significant theological statement in this passage is found in vs. 34:**
 - “My food is to do the will of him who sent me and to complete his work.”
 - We know its significance because the language of “he who sent me” is used over 20 times in John. What does this mean about God in Christ? (c.f. John 6:57, 8:29, 12:44, 13:20, 17:4 for instance)
 - “It is that mission, that is, the authority given to Jesus by God and the gift of God comprehended in it, that determines his entire existence.”! H. Ridderbos
 - Notice the intentional “solidarity” between the Father and the Son — solidarity in what exactly?
 - This “sentness” of God nature is very much related to the meaning of revelation itself, even as this revelation has climaxed in Christ. Who is God in Christ? And by the context of this story, who are the recipients? Is God in the Bible a mere parochial God, or is God in Christ universally relevant? What does this mean by way of implication?
 - How does this theological discussion comfort us?
- **An understanding of the church and our mission! (VS.35-38)** Interestingly, the significance of this theological statement extends beyond an understanding of God, but also an understanding of the church itself.. for the same phrase will be used to describe our mission as a church in John. (17:23, 25, 20:21) Notice then vs. 35ff
 - What time period is Jesus referring to about the fields of harvest? (e.g. related to his coming, and the time we are now in)
 - Who were the “Sowers” in redemptive history? (c.f. 1 Peter 1:10ff)
 - Who are the reapers in redemptive history (c.f. Mt. 28 and the church)
 - John 20:21* Jesus said to them again, “Peace be with you. As the Father has **sent me**, so I send you.”
 - How should this impact us? What should it say about our expectation and actions? Read then Mt. 13:16-18 and see if this helps to put perspective on this.
 - How does Christ admonish the disciples, and us, in this passage—e.g. notice the warning “do not say...” Notice too the promise “he who reaps receives a reward” What do you think this means? Who receives the reward ultimately? (Christ) Who then in union with Christ receives the reward? (those who participate with Christ in this redemptive work). Does this compromise our doctrine of Justification by faith? E.g. Notice Calvin’s comment on this: He references John 15:16, *I have chosen you, that you may go and bear fruit, and that your fruit may remain*, and comments:
 - It is for this purpose that Scripture everywhere mentions reward, and not for the purpose of leading us to judge from it as to the merits of works; for which of us, if we come to a reckoning, will not be found more worthy of being punished for slothfulness than of being rewarded for diligence? To the best laborers nothing else will be left than to approach to God in all humility to implore forgiveness. But the Lord, who acts towards us with the kindness of a father, in order to correct our sloth, and to encourage us who would otherwise be dismayed, deigns to bestow upon us an **undeserved** reward.*

IV. Scene 3: The Harvest Illustrated (vs. 39ff)

The conclusion of the story has the arrival of the Samaritans and their confession of faith concerning Jesus — it is nothing short of a story about the breakthrough of the kingdom of God and harvest.

- **Have you experienced the promiscuity of Christ in your life? Are you promiscuous?**
- *This would be a good time to pray for the harvest in our world today—in New Haven. Who can we pray for specifically today (specific people, categories of people, etc)*
- *Spend some time in prayer for our church, for greater “promiscuity” in our members and attenders, for greater boldness in bringing people to Christ wherein he can be found in word and sacrament and fellowship, etc.*